

Don't Go Broke

Before the Idea Becomes Reality

Where This Booklet Fits:

This is booklet 1 of 5 in the Don't Go Broke series.

Disclaimer: This booklet provides general educational information and is not formal financial, legal, or professional engineering advice.

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Before the Idea Becomes Reality

A practical field guide for deciding whether an AI app idea is ready to become a real project

Field Note

You have an idea. You are excited. You want to open an AI builder and start generating screens right now.

Wait.

Before you type a single prompt, read this.

AI has made it incredibly easy to turn vague ideas into visible output. But visible output is not a project. When you let an AI builder start making assumptions about your idea before you have defined it, you are pouring a foundation without knowing what you are building. That is how excitement turns into expensive, unmanageable chaos.

This booklet is a tool to protect your idea from premature execution. It is the first stage in the *Don't Go Broke* series because it focuses on the earliest, most preventable mistake a first-time

builder can make: **turning an unclear idea into a real project too soon.**

You do not need a business plan, a pitch deck, or startup jargon. You just need to slow down long enough to answer a few plain questions:

- What is the idea?
- What problem does it solve?
- Who is version one for?
- What counts as version one?
- What is not included yet?
- What would make this project too risky to start right now?

This booklet is not here to kill your idea. It is here to protect it from becoming expensive before it becomes clear.

Read it before you choose a platform. Before the blueprint. Before the build request. Before the idea becomes reality.

1. Introduction: Why This Booklet Exists

A few years ago, an unclear app idea stayed unclear for a while. You might talk about it or sketch it, but there was friction between the idea and the build.

Today, that friction is gone. You can open an AI tool, describe your idea, and watch it generate screens, database assumptions, and features before you have even decided what the project actually is.

That feels amazing. It also makes the idea feel more ready than it really is.

The danger is not that you are excited. You should be excited. The danger is that excitement can turn into a build request before the idea has earned the right to become a project.

Once AI starts building, the project creates gravity. Now there are files. Now there are features to fix and decisions you did not realize you had made. Now stopping feels like waste. That is how a vague idea becomes a real project before you are ready to manage it.

This booklet creates a pause before that happens.

Not a formal planning process. Just enough of a pause to decide what must be true before your idea becomes real.

Before you ask AI to build anything, answer this:

What am I about to ask AI to build?

Because the honest answer may be:

I know what I am excited about.

But I do not yet know what the project is.

That is not failure. That is the exact moment this booklet is for.

2. Why AI Makes Ideas Feel Ready Too Soon

AI can make an idea look real very quickly. You type a description, and a dashboard or a workflow appears. It feels like progress.

But a demo is not proof that the idea deserves to become a real product. A working screen does not prove the problem matters.

AI is excellent at making vague ideas concrete. This helps when you are exploring, but it can trick you into believing the idea is ready just because something visible exists. Once you see it, emotional pressure kicks in. You start reacting to the output: “Add login.” “Make it mobile.” “Add notifications.”

Now the project is growing. But growing around what?

If the original problem was unclear, every new feature makes the project harder to understand. If version one was never defined, every addition feels reasonable. AI can keep generating, but that does not mean you should keep building.

A quick demo is a sketch, not a permit to pour the foundation.

Before you trust the excitement of visible progress, ask:

What would make this idea worth building if AI had not already generated anything?

This question separates the actual value of your idea from the thrill of seeing something appear. The answer should come from the problem and the user—not from the fact that AI made something quickly.

3. The Difference Between an Idea and a Project

An idea says: *“This could be something.”* A project says: *“This is what we are building first.”*

Those are not the same. An idea can be messy, unfinished, and full of possibilities. A project creates obligations. It has scope, files, costs, and things that can break or drift.

Projects are real. Before your idea becomes a project, you need a boundary to protect you from building everything at once.

A project should have answers to four basic questions:

- What problem does this solve?
- Who is version one for?
- What does version one include?
- What is not included yet?

If you cannot answer those questions yet, you have a good idea, but you do not have a project.

This distinction matters because AI does not know the difference. If you give AI a vague idea, it will confidently build a vague project. It will create structure around assumptions you never

approved and fill in gaps with patterns that look reasonable but do not match what you actually need.

Once the idea becomes a project, it starts pulling in more decisions.

The question is:

Is this still an idea, or have I already started treating it like a project?

A second question may be even more useful:

What have I already committed to before defining the project clearly?

Maybe you have already committed to a feature, a platform, or a design direction. That is okay. You can still step back. The goal is to notice the difference between imagining and committing, so you can decide whether you are ready to cross that boundary.

4. What Problem Does This Actually Solve?

Many app ideas begin as features: “I want an app with profiles, reminders, dashboards, and groups.”

That describes what the app contains, but it does not explain what problem it solves. Features are just possible ways to solve a problem. If the problem is unclear, AI can still build those features—leaving you with a lot of visible work wrapped around a vague purpose.

Before your idea becomes a project, write the problem in plain language. Do not try to sound technical or impressive. Try to make it clear.

Use this sentence:

This idea helps _____ do, avoid, decide,
understand, or manage _____
because _____.

Examples:

This idea helps local bands book gigs because venues take too long to reply to emails.

This idea helps a freelance writer track outstanding invoices because unpaid bills get lost in long email chains.

The sentence does not need to be perfect. It just needs to be clear enough to guide your decisions.

A weaker version sounds like: *“The app has a calendar, an AI assistant, and payment processing.”* That avoids the real question:

What problem would still exist if this app did not?

If you can only describe features, the idea still needs a clearer job.

A useful problem statement gives you a way to judge version one. If the problem is “freelance invoices get lost in email,” version one does not need a full business accounting suite. It just needs to help the writer see who hasn't paid yet. The problem protects the project by helping you say yes to what matters and “not yet” to what does not.

Write the simplest version you can:

The problem is: _____.

Then ask:

Could someone understand this problem without seeing the app?

5. Who Is Version One Actually For?

Version one is not for everyone.

That can be hard to accept because your idea may eventually help many kinds of people. But “eventually” is not version one. Version one needs a first user.

Not a perfect persona or a market segment. Just a clear answer to:

Who needs the first useful version of this?

If your answer is “everyone,” version one has no anchor. Different people need different things, and those different expectations create conflicting screens, settings, and workflows. That is how a small idea becomes bloated before it becomes clear.

A first user protects you from that.

Use this sentence:

The first version is for _____, who needs help with _____.

Examples:

The first version is for a dog walker who needs help organizing daily client routes.

The first version is for a beginner gardener who needs help knowing when to water their indoor plants.

These examples do not describe the whole future. They describe the first person the app must help. That first user gives version one a test. If it helps them, version one may be useful. If it does not, more features will not save it.

You may eventually want agencies, commercial farms, or enterprise teams to use the product. But version one only needs to serve one of them. That is a way to keep the first project understandable.

Ask:

If this first user is the only person version one helps, what does it need to do well?

A first version needs someone specific to help. Without that person, the project drifts in every direction at once.

6. What Counts as Version One?

Version one is not the whole dream. It is the smallest useful version of the project.

That word matters: **useful**. Not impressive. Not complete. Not future-proof. Useful.

Version one should solve one clear problem for one clear first user. It should be small enough that you can understand it, review it, and control it.

If version one is too large, you may not know whether AI built the right thing. You may not understand which feature caused which bug, or whether the project is drifting away from the original idea. A smaller version one gives you a better chance to stay in control.

Use this sentence:

The first useful version only needs to let the user _____.

Examples:

The first useful version only needs to let the dog walker see today's route on a map.

The first useful version only needs to let the freelance writer log a sent invoice and click a button when it is paid.

These are not complete products, and that is the point. A first room is not the whole building, but it can prove that the structure stands.

If this one thing worked, would version one be useful enough to learn from?

If the answer requires ten more features, version one may be too large. Every added feature increases the load. More features mean more opportunities for AI to guess, which means more places for cost and confusion to enter.

Every feature should earn its place. Before the build starts, version one should be something you can explain in one or two sentences.

7. What Is Explicitly Not Included Yet?

A good version one needs a “not yet” list.

When you are excited, every future feature feels important: accounts, social sharing, payments, mobile push notifications, AI recommendations, analytics. Maybe you will need those. But not all at once, and maybe not in version one.

“Not yet” is not rejection. It is protection. It lets you keep an idea without letting it invade the first build.

Use this sentence:

```
For version one, we are not building  
_____, _____, or _____ yet.
```

Examples:

```
For version one, we are not building customer  
portals, automatic route optimization, or  
billing yet.
```

For version one, we are not building multi-user teams, Stripe integration, or custom email templates yet.

The “not yet” list is a parking lot, not a trash can. You are parking ideas where they cannot drive the first version off the road.

This list also protects you when you work with AI. If you do not tell AI what is excluded, it may assume accounts, settings pages, and admin dashboards are needed just because they are normal in similar apps. A “not yet” list keeps those assumptions out of your foundation.

Ask:

Which future feature is most likely to sneak back into version one?

Write it down. That is the feature to watch. If everything feels too important to exclude, the project boundary is not strong enough yet.

8. What Would Make This Project Too Expensive, Too Vague, or Too Large?

Some ideas should not become projects yet. That does not mean they should die; it means they need more clarity before they become real.

A stop sign tells you where the risk is before AI starts generating files and features around it. The goal is not to scare you, but to help you build with your eyes open.

Use this sentence:

This project is not ready if _____.

Instead of a long checklist, look for these practical warning lights. A warning light does not mean the car is worthless, but it does mean you should not keep driving as if nothing is wrong.

Stop Sign 1: You cannot explain the problem simply If you need a long explanation before someone understands the problem, the project is too vague. If you cannot fill in "The problem is: _____" cleanly, pause.

Stop Sign 2: You cannot name the first user If version one is for “everyone,” it will probably become too large. If you cannot name the first person who needs this, pause.

Stop Sign 3: Version one has too many jobs A first version should not solve five problems at once. If it needs to manage, recommend, schedule, analyze, and sell, it is too large.

Stop Sign 4: You cannot say what is not included yet If nothing can be excluded, the project has no boundary.

Stop Sign 5: The project depends on features you do not understand You do not need to be a professional developer. But if version one depends on things you cannot explain, review, or recognize when broken, the project may be too risky. Version one may need to be smaller.

Stop Sign 6: You cannot review whether AI built the right thing If AI gives you output and you would not know whether it matches the intended project, pause. If the project is too vague to review, it is too vague to build.

Stop Sign 7: You cannot explain what “done” means A project needs an end point for version one. If you cannot say what counts as a usable first version, AI may keep building past the point where you understand the project.

A stop sign means the idea needs more clarity before it becomes real.

9. Ready, Pause, or Do Not Start Yet

You do not need certainty. You just need enough clarity to move forward with your eyes open.

At this stage, there are three useful decisions: Ready, Pause, or Do Not Start Yet. All three can be good decisions.

Ready

The idea may be ready to become a project if you can clearly answer the core questions: the problem, the first user, the version-one boundary, the "not yet" list, and the stop signs.

Ready does not mean the project will succeed, nor does it mean you have solved every future problem. Ready simply means the idea has enough shape that you can protect it. It is clear enough to become a controlled project.

Pause

Pause may be the right decision if the idea is promising but one or more basic decisions are still unclear. Maybe the problem is almost clear, or you know the user but not version one. Maybe the "not yet" list is missing.

Pause is not failure. Pause is how you avoid building confusion into the foundation.

Do Not Start Yet

Do not start yet may be the right decision if the idea is too vague, too large, too expensive, or too dependent on assumptions to become a project right now.

That can be frustrating, but it can also save you from spending time and money on a project you cannot yet control. It means this idea has not earned project status yet. It can stay an idea while you keep notes, simplify it, or choose to build it later.

Before you move forward, make the call:

My decision is: Ready / Pause / Do Not Start
Yet

Because: _____.

If the answer is Ready, there is one more important thing to know. The next step is still not “ask AI to build it.”

10. Bridge to the Next Booklet: Before the Build Starts

If your idea is ready to become a project, you have done important work. You have defined the idea, the problem, the first user, version one, what is not included yet, and the stop signs.

That is enough to cross the first gate. But it is not yet enough to hand the project to AI and let it build.

This booklet helped you decide what the project is allowed to become. The next job is to design the project before AI begins building. That is where *Before the Build Starts* comes in.

The next booklet deals with the blueprint stage: what screens may be needed, what user flows may be needed, what data may be involved, what constraints matter, and what kind of handoff protects the project.

Those are not the questions for this booklet. This booklet ends at the moment when the idea has either earned project status or has not. If it has, carry these answers forward:

This is the problem.

This is who version one is for.

This is what version one includes.

This is what is not included yet.

This is what would make the project unsafe to start.

This is why the idea is ready to become a project.

Then design before you build.

You are not ready to build because you are excited.

Your job is to make the project clear enough to protect. You are ready to build when the project is clear enough to protect.

Back Matter

One-Page Readiness Checklist

Use this page before asking AI to build the app.

1. The Idea

The idea is:

2. The Problem

This idea helps _____ do, avoid, decide,
understand, or manage _____
because _____.

Or:

The problem is:

3. The First User

The first version is for _____, who needs help with _____.

4. Version One

The first useful version only needs to let the user _____.

5. Not Yet

For version one, we are not building:

1.

2.

3.

6. Stop Signs

This project is not ready if:

The problem is still vague.

The first user is unclear.

Version one has too many jobs.

I cannot say what is not included yet.

The project depends on features I do not understand.

I cannot review whether AI built the right thing.

I cannot explain what would make version one done.

7. Decision

My decision is: Ready / Pause / Do Not Start

Yet

Because:

One-Page “Not Yet” List

Use this page to protect version one.

A “not yet” feature is not rejected forever.

It is excluded from version one so the first project stays clear and controllable.

Not included yet:

Why it is not included in version one:

When it might be reconsidered:

Not included yet:

Why it is not included in version one:

When it might be reconsidered:

Not included yet:

Why it is not included in version one:

When it might be reconsidered:

Next Step

If your decision is Ready, continue to:

Before the Build Starts

Bring these answers with you. The next step is not to let AI build freely. The next step is to design the project before the build starts.

The Next Step

You are ready for the next phase. Proceed to booklet: **Before the Build Starts.**